

Tornado

Also called twisters, tornadoes are small but extremely violent spiraling windstorms. A narrow, rotating column of air extends down from the clouds, sucks up whatever lies in its path, and leaves a trail of destruction on the ground.

Mysterious end

It is difficult to predict the direction a tornado will travel. After a few minutes, most tornadoes disappear, although some can last more than an hour before new air stops being supplied, and they die away. It remains a mystery exactly how tornadoes end their life cycle.

Tornadoes contain some of the highest wind speeds ever recorded, at more than 300 mph (482 kph).

A sheltered room in a sturdy house or a storm cellar can protect people and animals.

Thunderstorms Tornadoes come from cumulonimbus, or thunderstorm, clouds. These clouds are dense and towering, and they also produce rain, hail, and lightning.



Dust devils These swirling plumes of dust develop from light desert breezes. They are not as powerful as tornadoes, but can still be dangerous.



Hurricanes These huge storms form over warm ocean waters. They have an area of calm in the center, which is called the eye.

